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Fred Staton

Tenor saxophonist Fred Staton was born on February 14, 1915 in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. He counts Coleman Hawkins and Chu Berry as influences on his own style, and his playing experiences range from a brief but arduous tour with a carnival group to touring the Scandinavian countries with his sister, the late vocalist Dakota Staton. Fred continues to perform with The Harlem Blues and Jazz Band.

Fred was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 12, 2008 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are interviewing for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have Fred Staton, saxophonist, as my guest.

FS: It's my pleasure.

MR: You guys put on a great performance this afternoon with the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band. You mostly do like head arrangements?

FS: Yes. Head arrangements.

MR: And how long have you been with them?

FS: I guess six years.

MR: You've been playing for a long time, you're 93, and you've seen a lot of change in this country I would imagine.

FS: Yes, I have.

MR: Yes. I'm wondering if you can tell me, when you were a child, was there a certain kind of music that made an impression on you, and where did you hear it?

FS: Well as a child growing up we had one of those hand-winding victrolas. And the most music that we had at that time were blues and what we call now Gospel music. So I didn't hear much jazz, because we didn't have it in the house. I actually didn't get exposed to jazz until probably in my teen years.

MR: Was there any discrepancy between — you said you had blues and Gospel.

FS: And Gospel, yes, right.

MR: So like your parents or your mother didn't think that blues was like nasty music?

FS: Oh no. No. As a matter of fact my mother was a self-taught pianist herself. She played a little piano. And my father tried to play a little piano. We had a — what do you call it — a player piano, the kind that you pump and you have the —

MR: The piano rolls.

FS: Piano rolls, yeah. And I can remember, now — in retrospect, now that I think of it, yeah, we did have — one tune that I can remember very vividly, "Way Down Yonder in New Orleans." Yeah. And I used to get a big kick out of just pumping that player piano and

singing along with the words to it. Yeah. So I take that back, I was exposed to some jazz a little before the teens, yeah.

MR: Was having a piano player in your house a big deal in the neighborhood or not?

FS: Yes, yes. Because everyone didn't have player pianos. It was a big deal, yeah. It was quite a thing.

MR: What about radio? What role did radio play in your house?

FS: Well we didn't have radio at that time. No we didn't have radio. I can't remember the first radio we got. It had to be probably in the twenties, yeah. Probably 1926, somewhere around there.

MR: And you went to the Pittsburgh public schools?

FS: Yeah.

MR: Were those segregated schools back then?

FS: There were, but it was just an accepted thing. That didn't bother us. As a matter of fact, the neighborhood that I grew up in was predominantly Polish, Lithuanian, and Slavish. There were only three colored families at that time. That's what we were, we were colored at that time. Only three colored families in the neighborhood. So there was segregation, but it was so subtle that we hardly noticed. We hardly noticed. We just accepted it for whatever it was. For example, if you went to the theater, there were sections that were set aside for the coloreds. And sometimes we would sit there, but by being in a predominantly white neighborhood, we wouldn't always sit in those sections because we were kids — we were all playing together, you know, so we'd go to the movies, we'd sit together. And there was, as I recall, there was no hassle. There was no hassle during those times.

MR: This would have been mid-twenties?

FS: Mid-twenties.

MR: Can you remember any of the movies you saw?

FS: Buck Jones?

MR: Okay.

FS: Tom Mix.

MR: And what did it cost to get into the movies back then?

FS: Oh gosh, I don't remember. Probably — I don't remember. It was very little. Very little.

MR: But it probably didn't seem like a little at the time, you know?

FS: No, no, no.

MR: What did your father do for a living?

FS: He was a mill worker. He worked in the mill. A foundry.

MR: And you ended up doing something like that.

FS: Yeah. I wound up in the mill myself. I did — when I graduated from high school I went into the mill for a while, and let's see, that was — no I didn't, no I didn't. I graduated in 1933. And I went into like housecleaning type of work. And also I worked for a haberdashery, a porter. I'd work during the week, and then on Saturdays they would let me dress up and work as a clerk.

MR: Okay. In the —

FS: The haberdashery.

MR: That's like a tailor, right?

FS: No, no. This is a men's clothing store. A men's clothing store. That's what it was.

MR: And meanwhile you were playing the saxophone by this time?

FS: I started out in the church of course as a Gospel singer. I was the lead singer. And the fellow who was sponsoring us decided that we should have instruments, maybe we should have an orchestra. So he interceded for us to get instruments. Somehow or other, I don't know how the heck he managed it, right in the middle of the depression with no money or anything, but somehow he managed to get us instruments. And my first instrument was drums. And we played in the church. We had a — what do you call it — one instructor who just instructed us all. There was no individual instruction. So we did that for quite a while, a few months. And meanwhile I was doing this other stuff, porter work and whatever else I could get on the side to make things go. And then there was a group who came through town, a carnival came through town. And they had a minstrel show. And they needed a band to go with this carnival. And that was even before I graduated from high school as a matter of fact, that was in 1932. So I left home with them.

MR: You left home with a minstrel band.

FS: A minstrel band. That was probably the toughest times I've ever had in my life. It was tough, really tough. We traveled through Pennsylvania, that's all. And I'm trying to think how long it was. It wasn't very long, probably about six weeks at the most. The first stop I remember was in Blairsville, then we went to Connellsville, Ford City and that's all that's coming to mind right now.

MR: Was it like in a tent type affair?

FS: A tent.

MR: And what kind of —

FS: The show — it was a minstrel show. And we had a black-faced comedian, and we had dancers, that is regular line dancers, and then we had what we call an exotic dancer. And the show just didn't go. It didn't go. So I left and came on back home. Hungry.

MR: Barely making enough to eat, huh?

FS: There were times when we didn't have it. There were really times when we didn't have it.

MR: Was the black-faced comedian, he was a black person?

FS: Yeah.

MR: But they did the coal, or what, they did cork or something?

FS: Cork. Yeah, yeah. As I recall the show was called "The Pork Chops Revue." I met a fellow in Denmark, last year as a matter of fact. And he sent me some pictures of two of the guys that I played with at that time. Because they went on — they came to New York from Pittsburgh, and went on and became quite good at playing. The Humphrey brothers. And this fellow had pictures of them. And I was just so glad to get them. Because all those years, I never —

MR: You didn't have anything from that time.

FS: No, no, no.

MR: Wow. That's paying some dues.

FS: Yes.

MR: Now you mentioned, in the middle of the depression — at the time of the depression were you aware that this is a depression? I mean some people say that while you're living through it, for some people it wasn't that much different. But was it a particularly hard time for your family and for you?

FS: At the time no, we didn't — it was just something that we adjusted to. It's just something that we realized well this is the case and this is what we will — we'll adjust to what we have to do. No it wasn't.

MR: And do you remember where you were when Pearl Harbor happened?

FS: Oh yeah. Yeah, yeah. I was on Center Avenue going to the Roosevelt Theater. There was a Roosevelt Theater right on Center Avenue, and I never did get to the show because the news came over the air and they blasted it.

MR: Mostly over the radio?

FS: Yeah.

MR: And then the newspaper the next day.

FS: Yeah, yeah.

MR: And did you assume — you were of age that you could have gone in the service, and you thought you might get drafted?

FS: Yeah. As a matter of fact I thought I would. But at that time I had four kids, and even though I was still playing music a little bit I was — was I in the mill then? I'm trying to think.

MR: Something I read said you were welding.

FS: Yeah, yeah, I'm getting to that.

MR: Yeah. Okay.

FS: No I think I was still in the foundry then. Later on, that was '41 so now you're talking about a couple of years after, during the time before, I thought I wanted to get out of the mill because I couldn't see an advancement there. So then I went to welding school. And I got to be a pretty good welder. As a matter of fact I was a first class welder. And we built, we worked on LSDs, landing ships, those kind that the back dropped out and the —

MR: The troops come out?

FS: Yeah, yeah, yeah. We made those, and I worked on these. I was good enough that I could work on the outside seams, and later on we did a few destroyer escorts. So then I got good enough to use —

MR: You're talking about the acetylene torch or something?

FS: No, no, no, no. It's another type of weld for the gun mounts. I'll think of it later.

MR: Okay. But that job was important to the war effort.

FS: It was essential. As a matter of fact, I thought maybe I would enlist. I really did. I thought maybe I would enlist. And I wanted to be a Marine. So I went to the Marines, went to all the examinations, and then when they found out that I had this exemption they said, "We can't take you."

MR: How did your wife feel about your wanting to enlist at that time?

FS: Well I didn't have that kind of a relationship so it didn't matter.

MR: Okay. All right. Meanwhile, who were you — you're starting to play the saxophone by this time.

FS: Yeah.

MR: Who were the people that you were able to hear, and were they influences on you?

FS: At that time you had Fletcher Henderson and of course Duke. The Count hadn't really come on to the scene at that time much. We heard a lot of Fats Waller from where he was broadcasting from — Cincinnati I think. I heard a lot of Fats Waller. And of course Coleman Hawkins, Ben Webster. And fortunately I did get a chance to meet Ben.

MR: Did you?

FS: Yeah.

MR: What was he like?

FS: Nice guy, a really nice guy. He drank a little bit too much, and smoked too much, but a nice guy. He was just open minded. There were times, like he would write out a solo for you. He was that type of person. "You want me to write a solo?" "Yeah." He'd write a solo.

MR: Neat. Would he come through town like as just a soloist or did he have a band, or did you hear him with Duke?

FS: I heard him with Duke, mostly with Duke, and then later on I did hear him with combos. But my biggest impression I have, the thoughts I have are those small combo numbers

that he did. Like even with Lester, you know, those small combos they did, where they could just let it all hang out and just be me.

MR: Uh huh. Not tied to an arrangement so to speak.

FS: No, no.

MR: Yeah. Well when you were playing today I heard Ben Webster. You have such a nice, velvety, beautiful tone.

FS: Yeah, thanks.

MR: And I was almost surprised to see you have a metal mouthpiece. A lot of times those things don't sound that mellow.

FS: Well that mouthpiece, that's an Otto Link. And it's probably, oh gosh, that's probably about 75 years old. It's old. It's old. Yeah, it's old, that's old.

MR: When was the best period for you, of actually music making, being a musician. Was there a period of years that things were really good in that department?

FS: No I think my best years have been the past ten years. Because prior to that I couldn't devote all of my energies to it.

MR: Right.

FS: So in the past ten years I've been able to devote a lot of my time and energies to it. So I've enjoyed it more now than I did then — I enjoyed it before, but I had to like divide my time and energies. But after I retired from work, you know I can honestly say that it's been the last ten years.

MR: And when did you move from Pittsburgh?

FS: Permanently in 1952. I had been away from there, you know, traveled different places, but I moved to New York in 1952. And that's where I've been ever since.

MR: Now in '52, Charlie Parker and Dizzy, that was sort of, even a little before that, sort of bebop was becoming more predominant and I'm wondering if it made an impression on you.

FS: Strange enough it didn't. No. I've always stuck to the old masters. Yeah. I admired them for what they did. Improvising, chord structure, things of that sort. I admired it. But I didn't have a particular inner feel for it myself. I could listen to it and enjoy it, but I didn't have a particular desire to do it myself.

MR: Yeah. And did you have a big band experience yourself?

FS: Yeah. During the war we had a band. And we would play prom dances on weekends, Fridays and Saturdays, most every Friday and Saturday. Every Friday and Saturday we would have a gig. And of course by me working in the shipyard there were times when I would maybe play the gig and then do half a shift in the shipyard.

MR: No break in between. You went from the gig to work.

FS: Yeah.

MR: Wow. That could get dangerous if you fell asleep on the job in the shipyard.

FS: No, no, no, no.

MR: Can you recall what you might have made, how much money you would have made on a weekend gig like that?

FS: I don't understand.

MR: Like if you had a big band—

FS: Yeah.

MR: How much money would each guy have made for one gig?

FS: During those times?

MR: Yeah.

FS: Probably twenty dollars. And that would have been pretty good money at that time, during those times.

MR: Yeah. What were you paying in rent at the time? Do you recall?

FS: No. Probably about forty dollars.

MR: Forty dollars a month?

FS: Yeah. I don't recall exactly, but probably that.

MR: And have you always kept close to Gospel music? It's always been a part of what you do?

FS: Yeah.

MR: In fact you still do some of that now don't you?

FS: I do. I have a Gospel group now. Yeah. As a matter of fact we just did a Gospel concert in Newport News, Virginia — what's today — three weeks ago. And what we did, we took Joey along, and he participated. He did very well. Very well.

MR: I've always been curious as to the level of spontaneity in a Gospel group. Sometimes you see a conductor bringing things in and out. How much of it is rehearsed and how much of it is just sort of spontaneous?

FS: The easiest way I can explain that is it's spiritual.

MR: Okay.

FS: That's all. It's spiritual. It's a feel, a spiritual feeling that they have. Sometimes it's spontaneous, sometimes it is rehearsed. But for the most part, it's spiritual.

MR: Are there people writing new Gospel music?

FS: Yes.

MR: And you guys do some of the — what was it Thomas Dorsey that did some of the early —

FS: Yeah. Thomas Dorsey.

MR: Is that still in your repertoire?

FS: Still. Yes. Definitely.

MR: And what is your role in this group?

FS: What I do, now, is I just do the background vocals, and occasionally maybe I'll do the first chorus. Like a number like "Walk Alone." I'll play the first chorus, and then the soloist will come in and sing up to a point and then we'll all join in, probably during the course of that tune.

MR: Do you have a church you go to now where they —

FS: Yeah.

MR: Gospel obviously.

FS: Yeah. We just did one last Saturday as a matter of fact. It's called the Baptist House of Prayer. They had us, a choir, and four different soloists. And in that setting, it's a tour group, that brings in tour groups from France and Germany and different places like that, and they bring them to these churches and they have different ones come in to perform. It just so happens that we were there for this one last week.

MR: Those tour groups, do they sort of get into it emotionally.

FS: Yeah, they do. They don't necessarily know the language, but they get caught up in the spirit and the emotion. They do. And well we, as a group we play to them, we have the tambourines and the hand clapping and all, and they just pick it up from us.

MR: I love the piano playing in Gospel music.

FS: Yeah.

MR: I wish I could figure it out.

FS: This piano player that we have today, this man, you should hear him play Gospel. Ooh. Well he plays everything, but especially Gospel. It's excellent.

MR: Do you think it's necessary to grow up with it to play it well?

FS: No, not really.

MR: You can just learn it?

FS: Yeah. It's a spiritual thing. Anyone can pick it up as you go along. Either you do or you don't.

MR: You were, let's see, in 1965 or so you were around 50. I think it was a couple of days ago that it was 40 years ago since Martin Luther King was assassinated.

FS: Yeah.

MR: And I remember, I was wondering at the time how much of an impact — did that have any impact in your daily life, that incident or that particular time, the Civil Rights Era?

FS: It was sad. And we were angry. I was angry, as most of us were. And it was a question of, why him? Because he was making such a great impact so far as the racial thing was going. The whole thing. Not only racial but just civil rights period. Well after the anger passed, then of course we said well we have to move on. But the initial impact was anger. I think we all had that.

MR: Right. If we leap to today, what's your opinion of the issues of racism in today's society?

FS: Oh we've made great strides. Great strides. It still exists, I mean we can't just completely deny it, it still exists. But we've made great strides. So I just take the position of be thankful for what you have and try your best to get more. That's all.

MR: That's a nice philosophy. Let's talk about Dakota for a minute. Did she show like talent from a young age?

FS: Yes. Dakota used to entertain the neighbors. She would just go around to different neighbors and sing for them. And she did that I guess probably from about eight years, seven or eight years old. And well as I said before I was playing with bands from time to time and I even took her on one of our gigs and she sang with us. I don't remember now exactly how old, she was probably about nine years old. Yeah, she's — from a very —

MR: And did your parents encourage that talent in her? Like this maybe could be her thing, like it could be a career for her?

FS: Well I have to reveal something about that, that the family — it was not a firm family structure. So I'll just let it go.

MR: Sure. When you were playing gigs with the band at that time, it was for dancing, right?

FS: Yeah.

MR: People danced. They didn't really sit and listen.

FS: They danced, yes.

MR: Yeah. What kind of dances were they doing?

FS: Lindy hop.

MR: Things like we see pictures of it at the Savoy Ballroom and that kind of stuff.

FS: That type. Not the throwing up and all that kind of stuff from the Savoy, but that type. Swing dancing.

MR: I've seen some neat, some of the video from back then, like with the Count Basie Orchestra.

FS: At the Savoy?

MR: Yeah. And they'd have these funny things with, they were almost like just little story lines, of Jimmy Rushing being on the dance floor and he's the last one standing or something. Were those things used in the movie houses? It seemed like they were just short pieces of some of the swing bands playing, and I wondered, where would you see them back in the thirties and forties.

FS: That's a good question. We wouldn't see them. They weren't there. No.

MR: So if you went to the movies—

FS: You wouldn't see them.

MR: No?

FS: No.

MR: I don't know what they used them for. I guess some of them were on what they called the kinescopes or something, like they had a juke box that you actually could see a little video.

FS: Oh yeah. Yeah, yeah. That, yeah.

MR: Okay.

FS: But for the movies, no.

MR: And in your record collection, did you buy 78s?

FS: Yeah.

MR: Who would be people you would buy?

FS: The people that I liked during that time: Ellington and Fletcher Henderson and Louis had a band, Louis Armstrong had a band at the time. Noble Sissle.

MR: Jimmie Lunceford perhaps?

FS: Jimmie Lunceford, oh yeah. Luis Russell. Benny Carter. And then of course the combos: Fats Waller, John Kirby.

MR: Did you get into what Louis Jordan was starting to do?

FS: Yeah, Louis Jordan, yeah.

MR: And I guess that was the late forties? Early fifties?

FS: Yeah. Well yeah.

MR: Okay. What is the most modern music that you like right now? Or — I'll have to use the word modern.

FS: It's hard to just pick one, because I like all music. I can listen to it all. It all depends on what mood I'm in at that particular time. I can put on, I can listen to Ben, for hours. And I can listen to Coleman Hawkins and Lester Young. So it all depends on the mood.

MR: Lester was great, huh?

FS: Yeah.

MR: There was a story that made me wonder if this was your case — something about he was a drummer first,

FS: Yeah, he was.

MR: But he got tired of all the guys leaving with the girls and he's still packing up the drums so he switched. Was that your case?

FS: Yeah.

MR: So he switched to the saxophone.

FS: You know, everybody is gone and I'm still, I'm still packing up these darn drums. What the heck is this? And it just so happens, this man had bought us a whole slew of instruments: saxophones, trombones and trumpets and clarinets. And the saxophone was still sitting there. And I said okay, I'm going for this. That's how it happened.

MR: Cool. Was it a tenor?

FS: Yeah, it was a Beuscher tenor, a silver Beuscher tenor.

MR: And you've been a tenor player most of your life then.

FS: Yeah. I have altos and sopranos now but I stick to the tenor.

MR: Yeah. The heck with the drums.

FS: That was funny. It wasn't so much the fact that the girls were gone, it was just the fact that everyone has gone, everyone has left, and I'm still there. And then you had to get transportation. You know, and it wasn't always available. So sometimes I'd be walking through the streets with it.

MR: With the drumset?

FS: With the drumset. So no, no.

MR: This is for — let somebody else do this part.

FS: Yeah.

MR: So getting back to Dakota, you went overseas with her, in the seventies?

FS: Yeah. In '77.

MR: Yeah? What was that like?

FS: That was delightful. As a matter of fact I have a recording that we did, we did a T.V. show and it was in a small town in Sweden. I still have that. It was a nice tour. A nice tour.

MR: How did she feel about her career? Was she happy with, you know, the way it went?

FS: Well Dakota had emotional problems all through her life. So it was up and down. It was hard to — there were times when she was up, and times when she was down.

MR: It's a tough business no matter what. If you had a grandson —

FS: I do have several.

MR: You have several. If they asked you about going into music as a career, what would your advice be?

FS: I would encourage it. Sure. Yeah. Do what you feel comfortable with. If you feel comfortable with it, do it. But if you don't feel comfortable, no, don't force yourself.

MR: Yeah. What do your grandkids do?

FS: None of them are in music. None of them. My grandson is in educational — he's a teacher in a public school. And I have four, four — yeah — four great grandchildren. None of them are interested in it, none of them. They come to see me perform from time to time, and they enjoy it. They're not interested so far.

MR: What was the — like the highlight of your musical endeavors? Has it been the last ten years as you've said?

FS: Yeah. Because it was always a struggle.

MR: Is there a part of — things have changed an awful lot, technologically. You know you've gone from seeing when your house didn't have a radio, to 78 recordings. Is there a part of technology these days that you like or that you take advantage of?

FS: No, there are parts that I wish I did, but my kids tell me that I need to join the twenty-first century. I don't know. I really don't know. And I can't put my finger on why I don't do it. Because I'm not a lazy person, I do stay fairly busy, but I don't have the energy. I really don't have it.

MR: Like with the computer or something like that?

FS: Yeah. I don't need that stuff.

MR: Do you have a CD player?

FS: Yeah.

MR: Okay. And you still have records?

FS: Yeah.

MR: I like records. I like to read the backs of them.

FS: Yeah, yeah. As a matter of fact I still have a turntable, but as I speak I'm going to have to get it fixed because there's something that's not working. I've got — as a matter of fact Vollmer gave me an LP, a Gospel LP with a couple of numbers that we do now. So hopefully I can get it fixed so I can listen to it. Because we do most of the old type of Gospel, as opposed to the new, bouncy stuff that you hear.

MR: Did you have an opportunity to record yourself, as a saxophonist over the years?

FS: No.

MR: Okay. But you're on some CDs now with the Harlem Blues & Jazz Band.

FS: Yeah.

MR: What's Doctor Vollmer like as a manager?

FS: He's quite a guy. A nice guy. Yeah. Quite a nice guy.

MR: It takes a lot of effort to do what he's doing. He probably sat in this room years and years ago.

FS: Oh yeah?

MR: Most likely. Yeah. And you guys are going to New Orleans soon.

FS: Yeah. New Orleans and that's the 25th of this month as a matter of fact. And then we're slated to go to Sweden, Denmark and Russia.

MR: Wow.

FS: It's set up. So hopefully I can make it.

MR: Yeah. Do you have a prediction about who will be our next president?

FS: No. I don't have a clue.

MR: It's something, huh. Do you have a favorite?

FS: I did, but now it's — I'm on the fence. And of course the reasons I'm just so afraid, the country is so corrupt. A person gets up so high and we shoot them down.

MR: Not too hopeful.

FS: No.

MR: Well it's been really a pleasure talking with you. And is there anything that you'd like to add that I haven't asked you?

FS: No, I don't think. I'll probably think of some things tonight when I'm in bed, but at the moment no.

MR: Okay. I did think of something just now. I was wondering, what was your impression of sort of the rock & roll revolution: Chuck Berry and Elvis and that whole thing. Did it make an impression on you at the time?

FS: No it didn't make an impression on me at all. Because I'm just jazz oriented. I liked it, but I only can take so much of it and then I'm going to go back to my comfort zone.

MR: Okay. Would you get in situations where people would want you to play rhythm & blues, you know, or "Night Train" or that kind of thing?

FS: Would I get into it?

MR: Yeah, were you in band situations where you'd do what the audience wanted?

FS: Oh yeah, sure. Yeah.

MR: Right. This is always a hard question but I'll try it anyway.

FS: Okay.

MR: Can you remember one of the worst gigs you ever played, or one of the best gigs you ever played?

FS: No I can't, come of think of it. Because there's been some good and been some bad but I can't cue in on them, you know, that was it. I'll probably think of it later, as I said before, but I can't now, no.

MR: Okay. Well it's been a real pleasure again, talking to you, and I hope tomorrow we'll be meeting some students up here, and I hope you'll share some of your reminiscing with them also.

FS: Okay. Be glad to.

MR: All right. Thanks for your time today.

FS: My pleasure. I hope I've given you some morsels.

MR: You certainly did.

FS: Okay.